

**PUNJAB AND
MAHARASHTRA**

Passing the Baton



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YASBANT NEGI



FAWZAN HUSAIN



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(CLOCKWISE FROM TOP LEFT) RANINDER WITH FATHER AMARINDER SINGH, SHARAD PAWAR AND DAUGHTER SUPRIYA SULE, NARAYAN RANE WITH HIS SONS, AND PETROLEUM MINISTER MURLI DEORA WITH SON MILIND

Lest you think political dynasties are dying, here is proof that politicians have a limitless supply of offspring and relatives to carry on their legacies. And nowhere is it more pronounced than in the states of Punjab and Maharashtra where the torch is unabashedly being passed on from one generation to the next. In Punjab, Deputy Chief Minister Sukhbir Singh Badal has declared that a family member will be fielded from Bhatinda and without doubt, the candidate will be none other than Sukhbir's wife Harsimran who will take on another second generation opponent, Raninder Singh, son of the former chief minister, Captain Amarinder Singh. Again, the newly-elected Punjab Youth Congress President Ravneet Singh Bittou is the Congress candidate from Anandpur Sahib and is former chief minister Beant Singh's grandson. Another youth leader hand-picked by Rahul Gandhi to test his electoral fate is Sukhwinder Singh Danny, son of former Punjab minister Sardool Singh. He is the party's candidate for the Faridkot Lok Sabha seat.

In Maharashtra too, politicians are ensuring that the baton stays within the family. Sharad Pawar has handed over his Baramati seat to daughter Supriya Sule while Congress MP Priya Dutt, who won the Mumbai North Central seat after the death of her father Sunil Dutt, has once again been fielded from the same seat and this time is pitted against Shiva Sena's Shilpa Sarpotdar, daughter of Sena leader Madhukar Sarpotdar. Milind Deora, son of Union Petroleum Minister Murli Deora is seeking to retain Mumbai South while NCP leader Ganesh Naik's son Sanjeev is the party's candidate from Thane. Industries Minister Narayan Rane's son Nilesh has been nominated by the Congress to contest in Ratnagiri Sindhudurg. But it's not limited to sons and daughters alone and Chief Minister Ashok Chavan is not far behind. Chavan's brother-in-law Bhaskarrao Khatgaonkar is the Congress candidate from the constituency once represented by him, Nanded. Some family reunion indeed.

by Shafi Rahman

THE MADANI EFFECT

The CPI(M)'s alliance in Kerala with the Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) led by controversial cleric Abdul Nasser Madani continues to trouble the Left.

CPI(M) General Secretary Prakash Karat won't say if he considers Madani's party communal but A.B. Bardhan and T.J.

P. ARJEEB



MADANI & PINARAYI VIJAYAN

Chandrachoodan, general secretaries of CPI and RSP respectively, say it is. Meanwhile, the Left Democratic Front campaign suffers. The three CPI candidates are unlikely to get PDP support while the CPI(M) looks set to gain from its new liaison. In Ponnani, the independent candidate backed by the CPI(M) and PDP may give the Muslim League a hard time.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan